

TIOBE Index March 2026

How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

lects language popularity based on search-engine hit counts across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ other sites. This report presents the March 2026 rankings and

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Rank	Language	Rating	YoY Change
1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 -- The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

	RISING				FALLING		
Perl	+13	24th → 11th	+1.05%	Go	-9	7th → 16th	-1.49%
R	+7	16th → 9th	+0.94%	C++	-1	2nd → 3rd	-2.90%
Swift	+6	26th → 20th	+0.44%	Java	-1	3rd → 4th	-2.37%
Assembly	+3	20th → 17th	+0.42%	PHP	-2	16th → 18th	-0.25%

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	-	-
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	-	-
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	-	-	-
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	-	-
Go	10	11	60	16	-	-	-	-	-
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

- Python rose from unranked (1986) to #1 (2026) over four decades
- C has remained in top 2 across all nine measurement points since 1986
- Java peaked at #1 in 2001 but has declined to 4th
- Lisp fell from #2 in 1986 to 26th today

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times -- More Than Any Other Language

Year	Winner	Notable
2025	C#	2nd win (previously 2023)
2024	Python	6th win total
2023	C#	Rising .NET ecosystem
2022	C++	Systems programming surge
2021	Python	5th win total
2020	Python	Data science dominance
2019	C	Systems programming revival
2018	Python	4th win total
2016	Go	Preceded current decline

Python leads with 6 total Language of the Year wins (2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024). C# has 2 recent wins (2023, 2025).

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

● Python Dominance vs. Decline

Python leads at 21.25% but posted the largest YoY decline (-2.59%) among top 5. Its fall from 25%+ peak suggests saturation or shifting interest toward AI/ML tooling.

● C's Resurgence

C surged to #2 (+2.02%), driven by systems programming, IoT, and embedded computing demand. Low-level control gaining renewed attention.

● Legacy Language Revival

Perl (+13 ranks), R (+7), and Fortran (top 15) show surprising resilience. Scientific computing and data analysis communities remain active.

● Go's Sharp Fall

Go dropped from 7th to 16th (-1.49%), the largest absolute drop in top 20. Rust's steady growth (+0.09%) may be displacing Go in systems programming.

● Concentration Risk

Python, C, C++, and Java hold 49% of the index. Betting solely on top languages carries risk -- consider diversification across domains.